

MACHINAL

adapted by ZACH GREENHAWT

original story by SOPHIE TREADWEL

CAST OF CHARACTERS

Young Woman	ACTOR 1
George H. Jones / Husband	ACTOR 2
Judge	
Priest	
Lawyer for Prosecution	
Reporter 1	
Second Man	
Man at Bar	
Husband's Voice	
Telephone Girl / Clerk 2	ACTOR 3
Mother	
Woman	
Wife	
Woman at Bar	
Matron	
Mother's Voice	
Wife's Voice	
Clerk 1	ACTOR 4
Bellboy	
Lawyer for Defense	
Reporter 2	

Guard

EPISODES

EPISODE I	To Business
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EPISODE VI	Intimate
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EPISODE VIII	The Law
EPISODE IX	A Machine

EPISODE ONE

To Business

Scene:

An office: a switchboard, filing cabinet, adding machine, typewriter and table, manifold machine.

Sounds:

Office machines, typewriters, adding machine, manifold, telephone bells, buzzers.

Characters:

A YOUNG WOMAN

A CLERK 1

A CLERK 2

JONES

BEFORE THE CURTAIN

Sounds of machines going. They continue throughout the scene, and accompany the YOUNG WOMAN's thoughts after the scene is blacked out.

AT THE RISE OF THE CURTAIN

All the machines are disclosed, and all the characters with the exception of the YOUNG WOMAN. Of these characters, the YOUNG WOMAN, going any day to any business. Ordinary. The confusion of her own inner thoughts, emotions, desires, dreams cuts her off from any actual adjustment to the routine of work. She gets through this routine with a very small surface of her consciousness. She is not homely and she is not pretty. She is preoccupied with herself - with her person. She has well kept hands, and a trick of constantly arranging her hair over her ears. The STENOGRAPHER is the faded, efficient woman office worker. Drying, dried.

The ADDING CLERK is her male counterpart.

The FILING CLERK is a boy not grown, callow adolescence.

The TELEPHONE GIRL, young, cheap and amorous.

Lights come up on an office scene. Two desks right and left. Telephone booth back right center. Filing cabinet back of center. Adding machine back left center.

CLERK 1

(in the monotonous voice of his monotonous thoughts; at his adding machine).
 2490, 28, 76, 123, 36842, 1, 1/4, 37, 804, 23 1/2, 982.

CLERK 2 *(in the same way - at his filing desk).*

Accounts - A. Bonds - B. Contracts - C. Data - D. Earnings - E.

CLERK 1.

(in the same way - left).

Dear Sir - in re - your letter - recent date - will state -

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Hello- Hello - George H. Jones Company good morning - hello hello -- George H. Jones Company good morning - hello.

CLERK 1.

Market - M. Notes - N. Output - O. Profits -P, -! *(Suddenly.)* What's the matter with Q?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Matter with it - Mr. J. - Mr. K. wants you - What you mean matter? Matter with what?

CLERK 1.

Matter with Q.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Well - what is? Spring 1726?

CLERK 1.

I'm asking you -

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

WELL?

CLERK 1.

Nothing filed with it -

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Well?

CLERK 1.

Look at A. Look at B. What's the matter with Q?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Ain't popular. Hello - Hello - George H. Jones Company.

CLERK 1.

Hot dog!

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

What number do you want? *(Recognizing but not pleased.)*. Oh - hello - sure I know who it is - tonight? Uh, uh - *(Negative, but each with a different inflection.)* You heard me - No!

CLERK 1.

Memorandum - attention Mr. Smith - at a conference of -

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Shh -! Yes, Mr. J. -? No - Miss A. ain't in yet - I'll tell her, Mr. J. - just the minute she gets in.

CLERK 1.

Report - R, Sales - S, Trade - T.

CLERK 2.

She's late again, huh?

CLERK 1.

Hot dog.

CLERK 2.

Was she out with her sweetie?

CLERK 1.

She ain't got a sweetie. Hot dog.

CLERK 2.

She lives alone with her mother.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Spring 1876? Hello — Spring 1876. Spring! Hello, Spring 1876? 1876! Wrong number! Hello! Hello!

CLERK 1.

Shipments — Sales — Schedules — S.

CLERK 2.

She doesn't belong in an office.

CLERK 1.

But I do! Hot dog.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Hello — hello — George H. Jones Company — hello — hello —

CLERK 1.

I'm efficient. She's inefficient.

CLERK 2.

She's inefficient. She's got J. going.

CLERK 1.

Going?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Going and coming.

CLERK 1.

Hot dog.

Enter JONES.

JONES.

Good morning, everybody.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Good morning.

CLERK 1.

Good morning.

CLERK 2.

Good morning.

CLERK 1.

Good morning, Mr. J.

JONES.

Miss A. isn't in yet?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Not yet, Mr. J.

CLERK 1.

Not yet.

CLERK 2.

She's late.

JONES.

I just wanted her to take a letter.

CLERK 2.

I'll take the letter.

JONES.

One thing at a time and that done well.

CLERK 1 (*yelling*).

Done well.

CLERK 2.

I'll finish it later.

JONES.

Hew to the line.

CLERK 1.

Hew to the line.

CLERK 2.

Then I'll hurry.

JONES.

Haste makes waste.

CLERK 2.

Waste.

CLERK 1.

But if you're in a hurry.

JONES.

I'm never in a hurry — That's how I get ahead! *(Laughs. They all laugh.)* First know you're right — then go ahead.

CLERK 1.

Ahead.

JONES *(to TELEPHONE GIRL)*.

When Miss A. comes in tell her I want her to take a letter. *(Turns to go in — then.)* It's important.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2 *(making a note)*.

Miss A. — important.

JONES *(starts up — then)*.

And I don't want to be disturbed.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

You're in conference?

JONES.

I'm in conference. *(Turns — then.)* Unless it's A.B. — of course.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Of course — A.B.

JONES

(starts — turns again; attempts to be facetious).

Tell Miss A. the early bird catches the worm.

Exit JONES.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

The early worm gets caught.

CLERK 1.

He's caught.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Hooked.

CLERK 1.

In the pan. Hot dog.

CLERK 2.

We beg leave to announce —

Enter YOUNG WOMAN. She goes behind the telephone booth to the desk on the right.

CLERK 1.

You're late!

CLERK 2.

You're late.

CLERK 1.

And yesterday!

CLERK 2.

The day before.

CLERK 1.

And the day before.

CLERK 2.

You'll lose your job.

YOUNG WOMAN.

No!

CLERK 2.

No?

Workers exchange glances.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I can't!

CLERK 2.

Can't? Same business.

CLERK 1.

Rent - bills - installments - miscellaneous.

CLERK 2.

Then why are you late?

CLERK 1.

A dollar ten - ninety-five - 3.40 - 35 - 12.60.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Why?

CLERK 2.

Excuse!

CLERK 1.

Excuse!

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Excuse it, please.

CLERK 1.

Why?

YOUNG WOMAN.

The subway?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Long distance?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No —

CLERK 2.

What?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I had to get out!

CLERK 1.

Out!

CLERK 2.

Out where?

YOUNG WOMAN.

In the air!

CLERK 2.

Air?

YOUNG WOMAN.

All those bodies pressing.

CLERK 1.

Hot dog!

YOUNG WOMAN.

I thought I would faint! I had to get out in the air!

CLERK 2.

Give her the air.

CLERK 1.

Free air —

CLERK 2.

Hot air.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Like I'm dying.

CLERK 1.

Same thing yesterday. *(Pause.)* And the day before.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes — what am I going to do?

CLERK 2.

Take a taxi! *(They laugh. Pause.)* Mr. J. wants you.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Me?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

You!

YOUNG WOMAN *(Rises)*.

Mr. J.!

CLERK 1.

Mr. J.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

He's bellowing for you!

YOUNG WOMAN gives the last pat to her hair — goes off into the door — back.

CLERK 1 *(after her)*.

Get it just right.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

It gives a line — it gives a line —

CLERK 1.

Hot dog.

CLERK 2.

She's artistic.

CLERK 1.

She's inefficient.

CLERK 2.

Mr. J. knows she's inefficient.

CLERK 1.

46 - 23 - 84 - 2 - 2 - 2- 1,492 - 678.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Hello - hello - George H. Jones Company - hello - Mr. Jones? He's in conference.

CLERK 1 (*sarcastic*).

Conference!

CLERK 2.

Conference.

CLERK 1.

Hot dog!

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Do you think he'll marry her?

CLERK 1.

If she'll have him!

CLERK 2.

Do you think she'll have him? How much does he get?

CLERK 1.

Plenty - 5,000 - 10,000 - 15,000 - 20,000 - 25,000.

CLERK 2.

And plenty put away.

CLERK 1.

Hot dog. Will she have him? Will she have him? This agreement entered into - party of the first part - party of the second part - will he have her?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Well, I'd hate to get into bed with him. (*Familiar melting voice.*) Hello - humhum - hum - hum - hold the line a minute - will you - hum hum. (*Professional voice.*) Hell, hello - A.B., just a minute, Mr. A.B, - Mr. J.? Mr. A.B. - go ahead, Mr. A.B. (*Melting voice.*) We were interrupted - huh - huh - huh - huhuh - hum - hum.

Enter YOUNG WOMAN - she goes to her chair, sits with folded hands.

CLERK 1.

That's all you ever say to a guy -

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

That's all you have to. (*To phone.*) Hum - hum - hum hum - hum hum -

CLERK 1.

Hot dog.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Hum bum huh hum humhumhum - tonight? She's got a date - she told me last night - humhumhuh - hum - all right. (*Disconnects.*) Too bad - my boy friend's got a friend - but my girl friend's got a date.

YOUNG WOMAN.

You have a good time.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Big time.

CLERK 1.

Small time.

CLERK 2.

A big time on the small time.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Hello - George H. Jones Company - Oh hello-

YOUNG WOMAN sits before her machine - hands in lap, looking at them.

CLERK 1.

Work!

YOUNG WOMAN.

Can't.

CLERK 1.

Can't?

YOUNG WOMAN.

My machine's out of order.

CLERK 2.

Well, fix it!

YOUNG WOMAN.

I can't - got to get somebody.

CLERK 1.

Somebody! Somebody! Always somebody! Here, sort the mail, then!

YOUNG WOMAN (*rises*).

All right.

CLERK 1.

And hurry! You're late.

YOUNG WOMAN

(*sorting letters*).

George H. Jones and Company - George H. Jones Inc. George H. Jones -

CLERK 2.

You're always late.

CLERK 1.

You'll lose your job.

YOUNG WOMAN (*hurrying*).

George H. Jones - George H. Jones Personal -

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Ain't it all set?

YOUNG WOMAN.

What?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

You and Mr. J.

CLERK 1.

You and the boss.

CLERK 2.

You and the big chief.

CLERK 1.

You and the big cheese.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Did he tell you?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

I told you!

CLERK 1.

I told you!

CLERK 2.

I don't believe it.

CLERK 1.

Hot dog. 5,000 - 10,000 - 15,000.

YOUNG WOMAN.

No - it isn't so.

CLERK 2.

Isn't it?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Not yet.

CLERK 1.

But soon. Hot dog.

Enter JONES.

TELEPHONE GIRL (busy).

George H. Jones Company - Hello - Hello.

CLERK 2.

Awaiting your answer -

ADDING CLERK.

5,000 - 10,000 - 15,000 -

JONES

(crossing to YOUNG WOMAN - puts hand on her shoulder, all stop and stare).
That letter done?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No. *(She pulls away.)*

JONES.

What's the matter?

CLERK 1.

She hasn't started.

JONES.

O.K. - want to make some changes.

YOUNG WOMAN.

My machine's out of order.

JONES.

O.K. - use the one in my room.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I'm sorting the mail.

CLERK 1 *(sarcastic)*.

One thing at a time!

JONES

(retreating - goes back center).

OK. *(To YOUNG WOMAN.)* When you're finished. *(Starts back to his room.)*

CLERK 1.

Haste makes waste.

JONES *(at door)*.

O.K. - don't hurry.

Exits.

CLERK 2.

Hew to the line!

CLERK 1.

Hot dog!

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Why did you flinch, kid?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Flinch?

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Did he pinch?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No!

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Then what?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing! - Just his hand.

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Oh - just his hand - *(Shakes her head thoughtfully.)* Uhhuh. *(Negative.)* Uhhuh.
(Decisively.) No! Tell him no.

CLERK 1.

If she does she'll lose her job.

CLERK 2.

Fired.

CLERK 1.

The sack!

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

A double bed! *(on phone.)* Yes, Mr. J. *(To YOUNG WOMAN.)* J. wants you.

YOUNG WOMAN

(starts to get to her feet - but doesn't).

Can't - I'm not ready - In a minute. *(Sits staring ahead of her.)*

CLERK 1.

5,000 - 10,000 - 15,000 -

TELEPHONE GIRL / CLERK 2.

Hello - hello - George H. Jones Company - hello - hello -

CLERK 1.

Profits - plans - purchase -

YOUNG WOMAN

(thinking aloud - to the subdued accompaniment of office sounds and voices).

Marry me - wants to marry me - George H. Jones - George H. Jones and Company -
 Mrs. George H. Jones - Mrs. George H. Jones. Dear Madame - marry - do you take
 this man to be your wedded husband - I do - to love honor and to love - kisses
 - no - I can't - George H. Jones - How would you like to marry me - What do you
 say - Why Mr. Jones I - let me look at your little hands - you have such pretty
 little hands - let me hold your pretty little hands - George H. Jones - Fat
 hands - flabby hands - don't touch me - please - fat hands are never weary -
 please don't - married - all girls - most girls - married - babies - a baby -
 curls - little curls all over its head - George H. Jones - straight - thin -

bald - don't touch me - please - no- can't - must - somebody - something - no
 rest - must rest - no rest - must rest - no rest - late today - yesterday -
 before - late - subway - air - pressing - bodies pressing - bodies - trembling
 - air - stop - air - late - job - no job - fired - late - alarm clock - alarm
 clock - alarm clock - hurry - job - ma - nag - nag - nag - ma -- hurry - job -
 no job - no money - installments due -no money - money - George H. Jones -
 money - Mrs. George H. Jones - money - no work - no worry - free! - rest -
 sleep till nine - sleep till ten - sleep till noon - now you take a good rest
 this morning - don't get up till you want to - thank you - oh thank you - oh
 don't! - please don't touch me - I want to rest - no rest - earn - got to eam -
 married - earn - no - yes - earn - all girls - most girls - ma - pa - ma - all
 women - most women - I can't - must - maybe -- must - somebody - something - ma
 - pa -ma - can I, ma? Tell me, ma - something - somebody.

The scene blacks out. The sounds of the office machines continue until the
 scene lights into Episode Two - and the office sounds become the sound of a
 radio, offstage.

EPISODE TWO

At Home

Scene:

A kitchen: table, chairs, plates and food, garbage can, a pair of rubber gloves. The door at the back now opens on a hall - the window, on an apartment house court.

Sounds:

buzzer, radio (voice of announcer; music and singer).

Characters

YOUNG WOMAN

MOTHER

Outside Voices:

Characters heard, but not seen

A JANITOR

A HUSBAND and a WIFE

AT RISE

YOUNG WOMAN and MOTHER eating - radio off-Stage - radio stops.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Ma - I want to talk to you.

MOTHER.

Aren't you eating a potato?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

MOTHER.

Why not?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I don't want one.

MOTHER.

Potatoes go with stew - here!

YOUNG WOMAN.

Ma, I don't want it!

Buzzer.

MOTHER

(her dull voice brightening).

There's the garbage.

MOTHER goes to the door — or dumbwaiter — opens it. Stop radio.

JANITOR'S VOICE *(offstage).*

Garbage.

MOTHER *(pleased — busy).*

All right. *(Gets garbage can — puts it out. YOUNG WOMAN walks up and down.)*

What's the matter now?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing.

MOTHER.

That jumping up from the table every night the garbage is collected! You act like you're crazy.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Ma, do all women —

MOTHER.

If it weren't for garbage cans where would we be? Where would we all be? Living in filth — that's what! Filth! I should think you'd be glad! I should think you'd be grateful!

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh, Ma!

MOTHER.

You just said you wanted to talk.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Well now — I want to think. I got to think.

MOTHER.

Well, you've got to eat! If you don't eat —

YOUNG WOMAN.

Ma! Don't nag!

MOTHER.

Nag! Just because I try to look out for you - nag! Just because I try to care for you - nag! Why, you haven't sense enough to eat! What would become of you I'd like to know - if I didn't nag!

YOUNG WOMAN.

I'm grown up, Ma.

MOTHER.

Grown up! What do you mean by that?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing much - I guess. *(Offstage sound of baby crying. MOTHER rises, clatters dishes.)* Let's not do the dishes right away, Ma. Let's talk - I gotta.

MOTHER.

Well, I can't talk with dirty dishes around - you may be able to but -
(Clattering - clattering.)

YOUNG WOMAN.

Ma! Listen! Listen! - There's a man wants to marry me. He says he fell in love with my hands.

MOTHER.

Who is he? Where did you come to know him?

YOUNG WOMAN.

In the office.

MOTHER.

In the office! Mr. J.?

YOUNG WOMAN.

The Vice-President.

MOTHER.

Mr. J, the Vice-President! His income must be - Does he know you've got a mother to support?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes.

MOTHER.

What does he say?

YOUNG WOMAN.

All right.

MOTHER.

How soon you going to marry him?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I can't, Ma! I can't! I don't love him.

MOTHER.

Love! - what does that amount to! Will it clothe you? Will it feed you? Will it pay the bills?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No! But it's real just the same!

MOTHER.

I'll tell you what you can count on! You can count that you've got to eat and sleep and get up and put clothes on your back and take 'em off again - that you got to get old -- and that you got to die. That's what you can count on! All the rest is in your head!

YOUNG WOMAN.

But Ma - tell me about love!

Offstage voices.

WIFE'S VOICE.

Don't.

HUSBAND'S VOICE.

What's the matter – don't you want me to kiss you?

WIFE'S VOICE.

Not like that.

HUSBAND'S VOICE.

Like what?

WIFE'S VOICE.

You look so silly – oh I know what's coming when you look like that – and kiss me like that – don't – go away –

End of offstage voices.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I don't care whether he's decent or not. I won't marry him.

MOTHER.

You talk like you're crazy!

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh Ma! Tell me – *(Words suddenly pouring out.)* Do you get used to it – you ought to be in love, oughtn't you? When he puts a hand on me, my blood turns cold. His hands are fat, Ma – don't you see? His hands are fat!

MOTHER *(stares at her bewildered).*

See what?

YOUNG WOMAN *(rushing on).*

I always thought I'd find somebody young and attractive – but nobody's ever asked me till now. And I suppose I got to marry somebody – all girls do –

MOTHER.

Nonsense.

YOUNG WOMAN.

But I can't go on like this, Ma! Sometimes I feel like I'm stifling! Sometimes in the subway I think I'm going to die – it's like I'm all tight inside.

MOTHER.

You're crazy.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh, Ma - if you tell me that again I'll kill you! I'll kill you!

MOTHER.

If that isn't crazy!

Offstage radio - a voice singing a sentimental mother song or popular home song.

MOTHER begins to cry - crosses to chair left - sits.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh Ma - forgive me! Forgive me!

MOTHER.

My own child! To be spoken to like that by my own child!

YOUNG WOMAN.

I didn't mean it, Ma - I didn't mean it! *(She goes to her mother - crosses to left.)*

MOTHER *(clinging to her hand).*

You're all I've got in the world - and you don't want me - you want to kill me.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I know, Ma, know. You rest, now, Ma - you rest -

MOTHER *(struggling).*

I got to do the dishes-

YOUNG WOMAN.

I'll do the dishes - You listen to the music, Ma - I'll do the dishes.

MA sits. YOUNG WOMAN crosses to behind screen. Takes a Pair of rubber gloves and begins to put them on, The MOTHER sees them - they irritate her - there is a return of her characteristic mood. The scene fades out. In the darkness, the mother song goes into jazz - very faint - as the scene lights into

EPISODE THREE

Honeymoon

Scene:

Hotel bedroom: bed, chair, mirror. The door at the back now opens on a bathroom; the window, on a dancing casino opposite.

Sounds:

A small jazz band (violin, piano, saxophone – very dim, at first, then louder).

Characters

YOUNG WOMAN

HUSBAND

BELLBOY

Offstage:

Seen but not heard, MEN and WOMEN dancing in couples.

AT RISE

set dark, BELLBOY, HUSBAND, and YOUNG WOMAN enter. BELLBOY carries luggage. He switches on the light by the door. Stop music.

HUSBAND.

Well, here we are.

Throws hat on bed; BELLBOY puts luggage down, crosses to window; raises shade three inches. Opens window three inches. Sounds of jazz music louder. Offstage.

BELLBOY (comes to man for tip).

Anything else, Sir? *(Receives tip. Exits.)*

HUSBAND.

Well, here we are.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes, here we are.

HUSBAND.

I'm going to wash up. *(Stops at door.)* Don't you want to wash up?

YOUNG WOMAN shakes head 'No'.

I do! It was a long trip! I want to wash up!

Goes off – closes door; sings in bathroom. YOUNG WOMAN goes to window – raises shade – sees the dancers going round and round in couples. Music is louder.

Re-enter HUSBAND.

Say, pull that blind down! They can see in!

YOUNG WOMAN.

I thought you said there'd be a view of the ocean!

HUSBAND.

Sure there is.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I just see people – dancing.

HUSBAND.

The ocean's beyond.

YOUNG WOMAN *(desperately)*.

I was counting on seeing it!

HUSBAND.

You'll see it tomorrow – what's eating you? We'll take in the boardwalk – Don't you want to wash up?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No!

HUSBAND.

It was a long trip. Sure you don't? *(YOUNG WOMAN shakes her head 'No'. HUSBAND takes off his coat – puts it over chair.)* Better make yourself at home. I'm going to. *(She stares at him – moves away from the window. He crosses to chair down left sits. Takes off shoes. YOUNG WOMAN leaves the window, and crosses down to the bed.)* Say – you look a little white around the gills! What's the matter?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing.

HUSBAND.

You look like you're scared.

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

HUSBAND.

You're with your husband, you know. *(Takes her to chair, left.)*

YOUNG WOMAN.

I know.

HUSBAND *(sitting)*.

Then come here and give us a kiss. *(He puts her on his knee.)* That's the girlie. *(He bends her head down, and kisses her along the back of her neck.)* Like that? *(She tries to get to her feet.)* Say - stay there! What you moving for? - You know - you got to learn to relax, little girl - *(Dancers go off. Dim lights. Pinches her above knee.)* Say, what you got under there?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing.

HUSBAND.

Nothing! *(Laughs.)* That's a good one! Nothing, huh? Huh? That reminds me of the story of the pullman porter and the - what's the matter - did I tell you that one? *(Music dims off and out.)*

YOUNG WOMAN.

I don't know.

HUSBAND.

The pullman porter and the tart?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

HUSBAND.

It's a good one - well - the train was just pulling out and the tart -

YOUNG WOMAN.

You did tell that one!

HUSBAND.

About the —

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes! Yes! I remember now!

HUSBAND.

About the —

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes!

HUSBAND.

All right — But I don't believe I did. *(She tries to get up again, as he holds her.)* You know you have got something under there — what is it?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing — just — just my garter.

HUSBAND.

Your garter! Your garter! Say did I tell you the one about —

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes! Yes!

HUSBAND *(with dignity)*.

How do you know which one I meant?

YOUNG WOMAN.

You told me them all!

HUSBAND

(pulling her back to his knee).

No, I didn't! Not by a jugful! I got a lot of 'em up my sleeve yet — that's part of what I owe my success to — my ability to spring a good story — You know — you got to learn to relax, little girl — haven't you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes.

HUSBAND.

That's one of the biggest things to learn in life. Now you go and get those heavy things off — and relax.

YOUNG WOMAN.

They're not heavy.

HUSBAND.

You haven't got much on -- have you? (Gets up.) Want me to help you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

HUSBAND.

You aren't afraid of your husband, are you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No — of course not — but I thought maybe — can't we go out for a little while?

YOUNG WOMAN goes toward bathroom door. Gets bag.

HUSBAND.

Where are you going?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I just want to — get ready.

HUSBAND.

You don't have to go in there to take your clothes off!

YOUNG WOMAN.

I want to.

HUSBAND.

I understand women — (*Indulgently.*) Go along.

She goes off — starts to close door. YOUNG WOMAN exits.

Don't close the door.

He looks around the room with satisfaction - after a pause - rises - takes off his collar; Still in his mood of satisfaction.

Next year maybe we'll go to Paris. You can buy a lot of that French underwear - and Switzerland - all my life I've wanted a Swiss watch - All my life I've counted on having that some day - more than anything - except one thing - you know what?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

HUSBAND.

Guess.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I can't.

HUSBAND.

Then I'm coming in and tell you.

YOUNG WOMAN.

No - no! Just a minute!

HUSBAND.

All right. Just a minute. (*YOUNG WOMAN is silent. HUSBAND laughs and takes out watch.*) 13 - 14 - I'm counting the seconds on you - that's what you said, didn't you - just a minute! - 49 - 50 - 51 -52-53-

Enter YOUNG WOMAN.

YOUNG WOMAN (*at the door*).

Here I am. (*She wears a little white gown that hangs very straight. She is very still, but her eyes are wide with a curious, helpless, animal terror. Now crying out*). Ma! Ma! I want my mother!

HUSBAND.

I thought you were glad to get away from her.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I want her now - I want somebody.

HUSBAND.

You got me, haven't you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Somebody - somebody -

HUSBAND.

There's nothing to cry about. There's nothing to cry about.

*The scene blacks out. The music continues until the lights go up
for Episode Four. Rhythm of the music is gradually replaced by
the sound of steel riveting for Episode Four.*

EPISODE FIVE

Prohibited

Scene:

Bar: bottles, tables, chairs, electric piano.

Sound:

Electric piano.

Characters

At Table 3: TWO MEN waiting for TWO GIRLS, who are
TELEPHONE GIRL of Episode One and YOUNG WOMAN.

AT RISE

*Everyone except the GIRLS on. At Table 3, FIRST MAN is pleasing, common,
vigorous. He has coarse wavy hair. SECOND MAN is an ordinary salesman type.*

At Table 3.

FIRST MAN.

I'm going to beat it.

SECOND MAN.

For the love of Mike have a heart! Listen - as a favor to me - you got to take
her off my hands.

FIRST MAN.

Maybe she won't fall for me.

SECOND MAN.

Sure she'll fall for you! They all fall for you - even my wife likes you.

Enter two girls - TELEPHONE GIRL and YOUNG WOMAN.

GIRL (*coming to table*).

Hello -

FIRST MAN (*grouch*).

Good night.

SECOND MAN.

Meet my friend, Mr. Roe. *(Grabs FIRST MAN by the arm and forces him to sit. They all sit, but the SECOND MAN goes to grab drinks.)* The same and two more?
(They nod.)

GIRL.

So we kept you waiting, did we?

SECOND MAN.

Only about an hour.

SECOND MAN.

Miss me?

GIRL.

I'll say so - Miss me?

SECOND MAN.

You don't know the half of it. Any other daddies?

GIRL.

Uhhuh. *(Negative.)*

SECOND MAN.

Let's beat it!

GIRL.

But - *(indicates YOUNG WOMAN.)*

SECOND MAN.

All right with you folks?

FIRST MAN.

All right with me.

SECOND MAN.

All right with you? *(To YOUNG WOMAN.)*

FIRST MAN *(quietly)*.

Stick around a while.

YOUNG WOMAN.

All right with me.

GIRL *(to FIRST MAN)*.

You be nice to her now. She's very fastidious. - Goodbye.

Exit SECOND MAN and GIRL.

FIRST MAN.

You're married, huh?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes - I am.

FIRST MAN.

All right with me.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Some men don't seem to like a woman after she's married -

FIRST MAN.

What's the difference?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Depends on the man, I guess.

FIRST MAN.

Depends on the woman, I guess.

Re-enter SECOND MAN and GIRL. They go to Table 3.

SECOND MAN.

Say, I forgot - I want you to do something for me, will yuh?

FIRST MAN.

Sure - what is it?

SECOND MAN.

Tell her about how you killed a man down in Mexico.

YOUNG WOMAN.

You killed a man?

SECOND MAN.

Two of 'em! With a bottle! Get him to tell you.

Exit SECOND MAN and GIRL.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Why did you?

FIRST MAN.

What?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Kill 'em?

FIRST MAN.

To get free.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh.

FIRST MAN.

There were a bunch of bandidos - bandits, you know, took me into the hills - holding me there - what was I to do? got the two birds that guarded me drunk one night, and then I filled the empty bottle with small stones - and let 'em have it!

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh!

FIRST MAN.

I had to get free, didn't I? I let 'em have it -

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh - then what did you do?

FIRST MAN.

Then I beat it.

YOUNG WOMAN (*nods*).

You used a bottle like that? (*She picks it up.*)

FIRST MAN.

Yeah filled with pebbles.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh.

FIRST MAN.

You haven't been around much, have you, kid?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

FIRST MAN.

You're different from girls like that other one - any guy'll do her. You're different.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I guess I am. Do - you - like me?

FIRST MAN.

Like yuh? You don't know the half of it - listen - you know what you seem like to me?

YOUNG WOMAN.

What?

FIRST MAN.

An angel. Just like an angel.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I do?

FIRST MAN.

That's what I said! Let's go!

YOUNG WOMAN.

Where?

FIRST MAN.

Where do you live?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh, we can't go to my place.

FIRST MAN.

Then come to my place.

YOUNG WOMAN (*getting up*).

I couldn't. (*She hesitates for a moment.*) Well - don't bring any pebbles.

FIRST MAN.

Say - forget that! Will you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I just meant I don't think I'll need anything to -

FIRST MAN (*leaning to her eagerly*).

You like me - don't you, kid?

The FIRST MAN crosses to YOUNG WOMAN with a wrapped bottle under his arm. She rises and starts out with him. As they pass the piano, he stops and puts in a nickel - the music starts as they exit. The scene blacks out. The music of the electric piano continues until the lights go up for Episode Six, and the music has become the music of a hand organ, very very faint.

EPISODE SIX

Intimate

Scene:

A dark room.

Sounds:

A hand organ; footbeats, of passing feet.

Characters

MAN

YOUNG WOMAN

AT RISE

darkness. Nothing can be discerned. From the outside comes the sound of a hand organ, very faint, and the irregular rhythm of passing feet. The hand organ is playing Cielito Lindo, that Spanish song that has been on every hand organ lately.

MAN.

What you thinking about?

WOMAN.

When I was little my grandmother used to have a big pink sea shell on the mantle behind the stove. When we'd go to visit her they'd let me hold it, and listen. That's what I was thinking about now.

MAN.

Yeah?

WOMAN.

Yeah. *(Pause. The music gets clearer.)* What's that?

MAN.

What?

WOMAN.

That music?

MAN.

A dago hand organ. I gave him two bits the first day I got here - so he comes every day.

WOMAN.

I mean – what's that he's playing?

MAN.

Cielito Lindo. It means Little Heaven. *(Pause.)* That's what lovers call each other in Spain.

WOMAN.

Little Heaven – sing it!

MAN

(singing to the music of the hand organ).

De la sierra morena viene, bajando viene, bajando; un par de ojitos negros – cielito lindo – da contrabando.

WOMAN.

What does it mean?

MAN.

Oh it doesn't mean anything. It doesn't make sense. It's love. *(Taking up the song.)* Ay-ay-ay-ay.

WOMAN.

I know what that means.

MAN.

What?

WOMAN.

Ay-ay-ay-ay. *(They laugh.)*

MAN.

You got a nice voice, honey.

WOMAN.

Have I? *(Laughs – tickles him.)*

MAN.

You bet you have – hey!

WOMAN *(laughing)*.

You ticklish?

MAN.

Sure I am! Hey! *(They laugh.)* Go on, honey, sing something.

WOMAN.

I couldn't.

MAN.

Go on - you got a fine voice.

WOMAN

(laughs and sings).

Hey, diddle, diddle, the cat and the fiddle, The cow jumped over the moon, The little dog laughed to see the sport, And the dish ran away with the spoon -

Both laugh.

I never thought that had any sense before - now I get it.

MAN.

You got me beat.

WOMAN.

It's you and me - La-lalalalalalala - lalalalalalalala - Little Heaven. You're the dish and I'm the spoon. *(A pause.)* Do you believe in sorta guardian angels?

MAN.

What?

WOMAN.

Guardian angels?

MAN.

I don't know. Maybe.

WOMAN.

I do. (*Taking up the song again.*) Lalalalala - lalalalala - lalalala - Little Heaven. (*Talking.*) There must be something that looks out for you and brings you your happiness, at last - look at us! How did we both happen to go to that place today if there wasn't something!

MAN.

Maybe you're right.

WOMAN.

Ain't it? Oh - We belong together! We belong together! And we're going to stick together, ain't we?

MAN.

Sing something else.

WOMAN.

I tell you I hadn't thought of singing since I was a little bit of a girl.

MAN.

Well sing anyway.

WOMAN (*singing*).

And every little wavelet had its night cap on - its night cap on - its night cap on - and every little wave had its night cap on - so very early in the morning. (*Talking.*) Did you used to sing that when you were a little kid?

MAN.

Nope.

WOMAN.

Didn't you? We used to - in the first grade - little kids - we used to go round and round in a ring - and flop our hands up and down - supposed to be the waves. I remember it used to confuse me - because we did just the same thing to be little angels.

MAN.

Yeah?

WOMAN.

You've had a lot of women, haven't you?

MAN.

Not so many sweeter than you, honey.

WOMAN.

I like to hear you say it. Say it again -

MAN

(protesting good humoredly).

Oh -

WOMAN.

Go on - tell me again!

MAN.

Here! *(Kisses her.)* Does that tell you?

WOMAN.

Yes. We're going to stick together - always - aren't we?

MAN *(honestly).*

I'll have to be moving on, kid - some day, you know.

WOMAN.

When?

MAN.

Quien sabe?

WOMAN.

What does that mean?

MAN.

Quien sabe? You got to learn that, kid, if you're figuring on coming with me.
It's the answer to everything - below the Rio Grande.

WOMAN.

What does it mean?

MAN.

It means - who knows?

WOMAN.

Keen sabe?

MAN.

Yep – don't forget it now.

WOMAN.

I'll never forget it!

MAN.

Quien sabe?

WOMAN.

And I'll never get to use it.

MAN.

Quien sabe.

WOMAN.

I'll never get – below the Rio Grande – I'll never get out of here.

MAN.

Quien sabe.

WOMAN *(change of mood)*.

That's right! Keen sabe? Who knows?

MAN.

That's the stuff.

A street light is lit outside. The outlines of a window take. Form against this light. There are bars across it, and from outside it, the sidewalk cuts across almost at the top. It is a basement room. The constant going and coming of passing feet, mostly feet of couples, can be dimly seen. Inside, on the ledge, there is a lily blooming in a bowl of rocks and water.

WOMAN.

I must go! *(Rises.)*

MAN.

Wait -

WOMAN.

I'm late! I must go!

She comes into the light. She wears a white chemise that might be the tunic of a dancer, and as she comes into the light she fastens about her waist a little skirt. She really wears almost exactly the clothes that women wear now, but the finesse of their cut, and the grace and ease with which she puts them on, must turn this episode of her dressing into a personification, an idealization of a woman clothing herself. All her gestures must be unconscious, innocent, relaxed, sure and full of natural grace. As she sits facing the window pulling on a stocking.

What's that?

MAN.

What?

WOMAN.

On the window ledge.

MAN.

A flower.

WOMAN.

Who gave it to you?

MAN.

Nobody gave it to me. I bought it.

WOMAN.

For yourself?

MAN.

Yeah - Why not?

WOMAN.

I don't know.

MAN.

In Chinatown — made me think of Frisco where I was a kid — so I bought it. I bet you'd like Frisco.

WOMAN.

I know a woman went out there once!

MAN (*indifferently*).

Every Saturday we used to cross the Bay — get a couple nags and just ride — over the hills — you know. You ever been off like that, kid? — high up? On top of the world?

She goes to the mirror of the dresser, to finish dressing. She has only a dress to put on that is in one piece — with one fastening on the side. Before slipping it on, she stands before the mirror and stretches. Appreciatively but indifferently.

WOMAN.

Yes.

MAN.

When?

WOMAN.

Today.

MAN.

You're pretty sweet.

WOMAN.

I never knew anything like this way! I never knew that I could feel like this! So, — so purified!

MAN.

It's a hell of a word — but I know what you mean. That's the way it is — sometimes.

WOMAN

(she puts on a little hat, then turns to him).

Well - goodbye.

MAN.

Aren't you forgetting something? *(Rises.)*

She looks toward him, then throws her head slowly back, lifts her right arm - this gesture that is in so many statues of women - Volupte. He comes out of the shadow, puts his arm around her, kisses her. Her head and arm go further back - then she brings her arm around with a wide encircling gesture, her hand closes over his head, her fingers spread. Her fingers are protective, clutching. When he releases her, her eyes are shining with tears. She turns away. She looks back at him - and the room - and her eyes fasten on the lily.

WOMAN.

Can I have that?

MAN.

Sure - why not?

*She takes it - goes. As she opens the door, the music is louder.
The scene blacks out. Curtain. The music continues until the curtain goes up
for Episode Seven. It goes up on silence.*

EPISODE SEVEN

Domestic

Scene:

A sitting room: a divan, a telephone, a window.

Characters

HUSBAND

YOUNG WOMAN

They are seated on opposite ends of the divan. They are both reading papers – to themselves.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Girl turns on gas.

HUSBAND.

Sale hits a million –

YOUNG WOMAN.

Woman leaves all for love –

HUSBAND.

Market trend steady –

Phone rings. YOUNG WOMAN looks toward it.

That's for me. *(In phone.)* Hello – oh hello, A.B. It's all settled? – Everything signed? Good. Good! Tell R.A. to call me up. *(Hangs up phone – to YOUNG WOMAN.)* Well, it's all settled, They signed! – aren't you interested? Aren't you going to ask me?

YOUNG WOMAN *(by rote)*.

Did you put it over?

HUSBAND.

Sure I put it over.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Did you swing it?

HUSBAND.

Sure I swung it.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Did they sign?

HUSBAND.

I'll say they signed.

YOUNG WOMAN.

On the dotted line?

HUSBAND.

On the dotted line.

YOUNG WOMAN.

The property's yours?

HUSBAND.

The property's mine. I'll put a first mortgage. I'll put a second mortgage and the property's mine. Happy?

YOUNG WOMAN *(by rote)*.

Happy.

HUSBAND reaches out to YOUNG WOMAN, she flinches.

HUSBAND.

You flinched when I touched you.

Phone rings. She gets up and goes to window.

HUSBAND *(in phone)*.

Hello — hello, R.A. — well, I put it over — yeah, on the dotted line! The property's mine. Now watch me. Tell D.D. to call me up. *(Hangs up.)* What are you looking at?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing.

HUSBAND.

You must be looking at something.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing - the moon.

HUSBAND.

The moon's something, isn't it?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes.

HUSBAND.

What's it doing?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing.

HUSBAND.

It must be doing something.

YOUNG WOMAN.

It's moving - moving - *(She comes down restlessly.)*

HUSBAND.

Pull down the shade, my dear.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Why?

HUSBAND.

People can look in.

Phone rings.

Hello - hello D.D. - Yes - I put it over - they came across - yep - on the dotted line - Now you watch me - yep. Tell B.M. to phone me. *(Hangs up.)* That was D.D. *(To YOUNG WOMAN who has come down to davenport and picked up a Paper.)* Aren't you listening?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I'm reading.

HUSBAND.

What you reading?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Nothing.

HUSBAND.

Must be something. *(He sits and picks up his paper.)*

YOUNG WOMAN *(reading)*.

Prisoner escapes - lifer breaks jail- shoots way to freedom - *(HUSBAND creeps closer)*

HUSBAND *(importantly)*.

(YOUNG WOMAN gets up.) My, you're nervous tonight. You inherit that from your mother. She was in the office today.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Was she?

HUSBAND.

To get her allowance.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh-

HUSBAND.

What would she do without me? A mother's a very precious thing - *(Resuming his paper.)* And a child's a very precious thing. *(Reading aloud)* Precious jewels. Sale of jewels and precious stones.

YOUNG WOMAN *(Suddenly)*.

I feel as though I were drowning.

HUSBAND.

Drowning?

YOUNG WOMAN.

With stones around my neck.

HUSBAND.

You don't breathe deep enough - breathe now - look at me. *(He breathes.)* Breath is life. Life is breath. What's the matter?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I can't sleep - I haven't slept. I want to go away.

HUSBAND.

But I can't get away now.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Alone!

HUSBAND.

You've never been away alone.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I know. Maybe I'd sleep.

HUSBAND.

Wait. We'll take a trip - we'll go to Europe - I'll get my watch - I'll get my Swiss watch - I've always wanted a Swiss watch that I bought right there - isn't that funny? Wait - wait. *(YOUNG WOMAN comes down to davenport - sits. Husband resumes his paper.)* Another revolution below the Rio Grande.

He resumes his paper. YOUNG WOMAN sits, staring ahead of her. The music of the hand organ sounds off very dimly, playing Cielito Lindo. Voices begin to sing it - 'Ay-ay-ay-ay' - and then the words - the music and voices get louder.

THE VOICE OF HER LOVER.

They were a bunch of bandidos - bandits you know - holding me there - what was I to do-I had to get free - didn't I? I had to get free -

VOICES.

Free - free - free -

YOUNG WOMAN.

Below the Rio Grande?

HUSBAND.

Yes - another -

YOUNG WOMAN.

Anyone - hurt?

HUSBAND.

No.

LOVER.

I filled an empty bottle with small stones -

VOICES.

Stones - stones -- precious stones - millstones - stones - stones - millstones

YOUNG WOMAN.

Any prisoners?

HUSBAND.

No.

LOVER.

Just a bottle with small stones.

VOICES.

Stones - stones - small stones -

LOVER.

You only need a bottle with small stones.

YOUNG WOMAN.

All free?

HUSBAND.

All free.

VOICES.

Stones - stones - small stones -

VOICE OF A HUCKSTER.

Stones for sale - stones - stones - small stones - precious stones -

VOICES.

Stones - stones - precious stones -

LOVER.

Had to get free, didn't I? Free?

VOICES.

Free? Free?

LOVER.

Quien sabe? Who knows? Who knows?

VOICES.

Who'd know? Who'd know? Who'd know?

HUCKSTER.

Stones - stones - small stones - big stones - millstones - cold stones - head stones -

VOICES.

Head stones - head stones - head stones.

The music - the voices - mingle - increase - the YOUNG WOMAN flies from her chair and cries out in terror.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh! Oh!

The scene blacks out - the music and the dim voices, 'Stones - stones - stones,' continue until the scene lights for Episode Eight.

EPISODE EIGHT

The Law

Scene:

Courtroom.

Sounds:

Clicking of telegraph instruments offstage.

Characters:

LAWYERS

REPORTERS

JUDGE

YOUNG WOMAN

The words and movements of all these people except the YOUNG WOMAN are routine - mechanical. Each is going through the motions of his own game.

AT RISE

All assembled, except JUDGE.

Enter JUDGE.

JUDGE sits. All sit. LAWYER FOR DEFENSE gets to his feet -He is the verbose, 'eloquent' typical criminal defense lawyer. JUDGE signs to him to wait - turns to LAW CLERKS, grouped at the foot of the bench.

JUDGE

(to LAWYER FOR DEFENSE).

In the people of the State of Colorado versus Helen Jones. Is the Defense ready to proceed?

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

We're ready, your Honor.

JUDGE.

Proceed.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Helen Jones.

YOUNG WOMAN rises.

Mrs. Jones, will you take the stand?

YOUNG WOMAN goes to witness stand.

REPORTER 1 *(writing rapidly)*.

The defense surprised the court this morning by placing the accused woman on the stand. Trembling and scarcely able to stand, Helen Jones, accused murderess—

JUDGE *(mumbling — with Bible)*.

Do you swear to tell the truth, the whole truth and nothing but the truth — so help you God?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I do.

JUDGE.

You may sit.

She sits in the witness chair.

REPORTER 1.

What is your name?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Helen Jones.

REPORTER 1.

Your age?

YOUNG WOMAN *(hesitates — then)*.

Twenty-nine.

REPORTER 1.

Where do you live?

YOUNG WOMAN.

In prison.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Mrs. Jones, you were married to George H. Jones for six years, were you not?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I was.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

In those six years of married life with your late husband, the late George H. Jones, did you EVER have a quarrel?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No, sir.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Six years without one quarrel! Six years! Gentlemen of the jury, I ask you to consider this fact! Six years of married life without a quarrel. (*The JURY grins.*) Task you to consider it seriously! Very seriously! Who of us-and this is not intended as any reflection on the sacred institution of marriage - no - but!

JUDGE.

Proceed with your witness.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

You have one child - have you not, Mrs. Jones?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes, sir.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Since the demise of the late Mr. Jones you are the only parent she has living, are you not?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes, sir.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE (*quickly*).

And now, Mrs. Jones, I will ask you - the law expects me to ask you - it demands that I ask you - did you - or did you not - on the night of June 2nd last or the morning of June 3rd last - kill your husband, the late George H. Jones - did you, or did you not?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I did not.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

You did not?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I did not.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

You did not! Of course you did not! (*Quickly.*) Now, Mrs. Jones, will you tell the jury in your own words exactly what happened on the night of June 2nd or the morning of June 3rd last, at the time your husband was killed.

YOUNG WOMAN.

I was awakened by hearing somebody - something - in the room, and I saw two men standing by my husband's bed.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Your husband's bed - that was also your bed, was it not, Mrs. Jones?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Then explain just what you meant by saying 'my husband's bed'. You meant his side of the bed, didn't you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes. His side. I heard a noise and I awoke and saw two men. standing beside my husband's side of the bed.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Two men?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Can you describe them?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Not very well - I couldn't see them very well.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

You couldn't see them very well. Mrs. Jones, when you suddenly awoke and saw two big dark looking men standing beside your bed, you didn't have time to do anything - did you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No. Before I could do anything - one of them raised - something in his hand and struck Mr. Jones over the head with it.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

I see. What did you do then, Mrs. Jones?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I saw Mr. Jones was bleeding from the temple. I got towels and tried to stop it, and then I realized he had - passed away

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

I see. What did you do then?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I didn't know what to do. But I thought I'd better call the police. So I went to the telephone and called the police.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

The police came, didn't they?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes - they came.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE *(quickly)*.

And that is all you know concerning the death of your husband in the late hours of June 2nd or the early hours of June 3rd last, isn't it?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes sir.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE (To LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION).

Take the witness.

REPORTER 2 (*writing*).

The accused woman told a straightforward story of —

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

When those two dark men turned and ran out of the room, you made no effort to follow them or cry out after them, did you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No sir. I saw Mr. Jones was hurt.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Ah! You saw Mr. Jones was hurt! You saw this — how did you see it?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Bright Moonlight — from the window.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

It was bright moon — you are sure of that?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

It was bright moon. Yet you could not see two big dark looking men — but you could see your husband bleeding from the temple.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes sir.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

You sat there a long while, didn't you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I don't know.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

You don't know? (Showing her the neck of a broken bottle.) Mrs. Jones, did you ever see this before?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I think so.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

What do you think it is?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I think it's the bottle that was used against Mr. Jones.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Used against him - yes - that's right. This neck and these broken pieces and these pebbles were found on the floor and scattered over the bed. There were no fingerprints, Mrs. Jones, on this bottle. None at all. Doesn't that seem strange to you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

You are in the habit of wearing rubber gloves at night, Mrs. Jones - are you not? To protect - to soften your hands - are you not?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I used to. Before I was married.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

And after your marriage you gave it up?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Mr. Jones did not like the feeling of them.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

I see - so after your marriage you never wore gloves at night any more?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Mrs. Jones, isn't it true that you began wearing your rubber gloves again - in spite of your husband's expressed dislike - about a year ago - a year ago this spring?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION (*to JUDGE*).

I'd like to introduce these gloves as evidence at this time, your Honor.

JUDGE.

Exhibit 24.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

I'll return to them later - now, Mrs. Jones - this nightgown - you recognize it, don't you?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

You were wearing it the night your husband was murdered, were you not?

YOUNG WOMAN.

The night he died - yes.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

This was found rolled up and wet - why was it wet, Mrs. Jones?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I had tried to wash it.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Wash it? I thought you had just sat?

YOUNG WOMAN.

First - I tried to make things clean. There was blood on it.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Mrs. Jones, why did you try so desperately to wash that blood away - before you called the police?

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

I object!

JUDGE.

Objection overruled.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Now, Mrs. Jones, these stones - when did you first see them?

YOUNG WOMAN.

The night my husband was done away with.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Before that night your husband was murdered - you never saw them? Never before then?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No sir.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Mrs. Jones, do you remember about a year ago, a year ago this spring, bringing home to your house - a lily, a Chinese water lily?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No - I don't think I do.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

I'll show you this bowl, Mrs. Jones. Does that refresh your memory?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I remember the bowl - but I don't remember - the lily.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

It is yours, isn't it?

YOUNG WOMAN.

It was in my house - yes.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Where did you get it?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I don't remember.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

You don't remember about a year ago bringing this bowl into your bedroom filled with small stones and some water and a lily? You don't remember tending very carefully that lily till it died? And when it died you don't remember hiding the bowl full of little stones away on the top shelf of your closet - and keeping it there until - you don't remember?

YOUNG WOMAN.

No, I don't remember.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

But you do remember the bowl?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes. It was in my house - you found it in my house.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION *(producing paper)*.

Your Honor, I'd like to introduce this paper in evidence at this time.

JUDGE.

What is it?

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

It is an affidavit taken in the State of Guanajuato, Mexico.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Mexico? Your Honor, I protest. A Mexican affidavit! Is this the United States of America or isn't it?

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

It's properly executed - sworn to before a notary - and certified to by an American Consul.

JUDGE.

What is the purpose of this document - who signed it?

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

It is signed by one Richard Roe, and its purpose is to refresh the memory of the witness on the point at issue - and incidentally supply a motive for this murder - this brutal and cold-blooded murder of a sleeping man by-

JUDGE.

You may introduce the evidence.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

I wish to read the evidence to the jury at this time.

JUDGE.

Proceed.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

I object.

JUDGE.

Objection overruled.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Exception.

JUDGE.

Noted.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Why is this witness himself not brought into court — so he can be cross-questioned?

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

The witness is a resident of the Republic of Mexico and as such not subject to subpoena as a witness to this court.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

If he was out of the jurisdiction of this court how did you get this affidavit out of him?

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

This affidavit was made voluntarily by the deponent in the furtherance of justice.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

I suppose you didn't threaten him with extradition on some other trumped-up charge so that —

JUDGE.

Order!

JUDGE.

Proceed with the evidence.

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION (*reading*).

In the matter of the State of Colorado vs. Helen Jones, I Richard Roe, being of sound mind, do herein depose and state that I know the accused, Helen Jones, and have known her for a period of over one year immediately preceding the date of the signature on this affidavit. That I first met the said Helen Jones in a so-called speak-easy somewhere in the West 40s in New York City. That on the day I met her, she went with me to my room, also somewhere in the West 40s in New York City, where we had intimate relations—

YOUNG WOMAN (*moans*).

Oh!

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION (*continues reading*).

— and where I gave her a blue bow! filled with pebbles, also containing a flowering lily. That from the first day we met until I departed for Mexico in the Fall, the said Helen Jones was an almost daily visitor to my room where we continued to —

YOUNG WOMAN.

No! No! (*Moans.*)

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

What is it, Mrs. Jones — what is it?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Don't read any more! No more!

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

Why not!

YOUNG WOMAN.

I did it! I did it! I did it!

LAWYER FOR PROSECUTION.

You confess?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes - I did it!

JUDGE.

You confess you killed your husband?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I put him out of the way - yes.

JUDGE.

Why?

YOUNG WOMAN.

To be free.

JUDGE.

To be free? Is that the only reason?

YOUNG WOMAN.

Yes.

JUDGE.

If you just wanted to be free - why didn't you divorce

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh I couldn't do that!! I couldn't hurt him like that!

JUDGE.

Mrs. Jones, why -

YOUNG WOMAN begins to moan - suddenly - as though the realization of the enormity of her isolation had just come upon her. It is a sound of desolation, of agony, of human woe. It continues until the end of the scene.

Why -?

YOUNG WOMAN cannot speak.

LAWYER FOR DEFENSE.

Your Honor, I ask a recess to —

JUDGE.

Court's adjourned.

SPECTATORS begin to file out. The YOUNG WOMAN continues in the witness box, unseeing, unheeding.

REPORTER 2.

Murderess confesses. I did it! Woman cries!

There is a great burst of speed from the telegraphic instruments. They keep up a constant accompaniment to the WOMAN 's moans. The scene blacks out as the courtroom empties, and two policemen go to stand by the woman. The sound of the telegraph instruments continues until the scene lights into Episode Nine — and the prayers of the PRIEST.

EPISODE NINE

A Machine

Scene:

A prison room. The front bars face the audience. They are set back far enough to permit a clear passageway across the stage.

Sounds:

The voice of a Person singing; the whir of an aeroplane flying.

Characters

YOUNG WOMAN

A PRIEST

A GUARD

A MATRON

MOTHER

AT RISE

in front of the bars, at one side, sits a MAN; at the opposite side, a WOMAN - the GUARD and the MATRON.

Inside the bars, a MAN and a WOMAN - the YOUNG WOMAN and a PRIEST. The YOUNG WOMAN sits still with folded hands. The PRIEST is praying.

PRIEST.

Hear, oh Lord, my prayer; and let my cry come to Thee. Turn not away Thy face from me in the day when I am in trouble. For my days are vanished like smoke; and my heart is withered. I have watched and become as a sparrow all alone on the housetop. But Thou, oh Lord, endurest forever. The time is come.

Voice of Someone offstage - begins to sing a spiritual.

PRIEST.

The Lord hath looked upon the earth, that He might hear the groans of them that are in fetters-

Voice of Person grow louder.

GUARD. (From Offstage.)

Stop that yelling.

YOUNG WOMAN.

No, let him sing. He helps me.

MATRON.

You can't hear the Father.

YOUNG WOMAN.

He helps me.

PRIEST.

Don't I help you, daughter?

YOUNG WOMAN.

I understand him. He is condemned. I understand him.

The voice of the person goes on louder, drowning out the voice of the PRIEST.

Enter A BARBER. There is a rattling of keys.

PRIEST *(chanting in Latin).*

Gratiam tuam, quaesumus, Domine-

GUARD. *(Overlapping PRIEST)*

How is she?

MATRON.

Calm.

YOUNG WOMAN *(rising).*

I am ready.

GUARD.

Then sit down.

YOUNG WOMAN *(in a steady voice).*

Aren't you the death guard come to take me?

GUARD.

No, I ain't the death guard. I'm the barber guard.

YOUNG WOMAN.

The barber.

MATRON.

Your hair must be cut.

GUARD.

Regulations. Routine.

The GUARD draws near her.

YOUNG WOMAN.

No! No! Don't touch me — touch me!

They take her and put her down in the chair, cut a patch from her hair.

I will not be submitted! Not now! I'm going to die — I won't submit! Am I never to be let alone?

GUARD

(finishing cutting a patch from her hair).

You'll submit, my lady. Right to the end, you'll submit! There, and a neat job too.

MATRON.

Very neat.

YOUNG WOMAN *(her calm shattered).*

Father, Father! Why was I born? *(She is now weeping).* Submit! Submit! Is nothing mine? The hair on my head! The very hair on my head—

PRIEST.

Praise God.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Am I never to be let alone! Never to have peace! When I'm dead, won't I have peace?

PRIEST.

I am the Resurrection and the Life.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Life has been hell to me, Father!

PRIEST.

Life has been hell to you, daughter, because you never knew God! Gloria in excelsis Deo.

YOUNG WOMAN.

How could I know Him, Father? He never was around me.

A shadow falls across the passage in the front of the stage - and there is a whirring sound.

What is that? Father! Guard! What is that?

GUARD.

An Aeroplane.

MATRON. *(While Leaving.)*

Aeroplane.

PRIEST.

God in his Heaven.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Look, Father! A man flying! He has wings - but he isn't free! I've been free, Father! For one moment - down here on earth - I have been free, Father. For one moment, down here on earth, I was free. When I did what I did, I was free. Free and not afraid. How can that be? A sin - a mortal sin - but it made me free.

PRIEST.

Your sins are forgiven.

YOUNG WOMAN.

And that other sin - that sin of love - that's all I ever knew of Heaven. How can that be a sin?

PRIEST.

Confess to Almighty God.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Oh, Father, pray for me - a prayer - that I can understand!

Enter the MOTHER. She comes along the passageway and stops before the bars.

YOUNG WOMAN *(Recoiling)*.

Who's that woman?

GUARD.

Your mother.

YOUNG WOMAN.

She's a stranger - take her away - she's a stranger.

GUARD.

She's come to say goodbye to you -

YOUNG WOMAN.

But she's never known me - never known me - ever - *(To the MOTHER.)* Go away!
You're a stranger! Stranger! Stranger! *(MOTHER turns and starts away. Reaching out her hands to her.)* Oh Mother! Mother! *(They embrace through the bars.)*

PRIEST.

Come, daughter.

GUARD.

It's time.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Wait! Mother, my child; my little strange child! I never knew her! She'll never know me! Let her live, Mother. Let her live! Live! Tell her -

PRIEST.

Come, daughter.

The MOTHER goes away.

GUARD.

It's time.

YOUNG WOMAN.

Wait! Wait! Tell her! Wait! Just a minute more! There's so much I want to tell her - Wait -

GUARD takes YOUNG WOMAN by the arms and leads her through the bars. PRIEST follows, praying.

PRIEST.

Lord have mercy. Christ have mercy. Holy Mary, pray for us. St. Michael, pray for us. St. Gabriel, pray for us. Pray for us. Pray for us.

His voice dies out - gets louder - continues until the end. Sounds of the machine in the beginning begin to play and get louder.

VOICE 1.

Suppose the machine shouldn't work!

VOICE 2.

It'll work! - It always works!

VOICE 3.

Hush!

PRIEST.

Oh Lord, deliver us from all evil-

VOICE 1

Her lips are moving - what is she saying?

VOICE 2.

Nothing.

VOICE 3.

Hush!

PRIEST.

Christ have mercy. Lord have mercy.

VOICE 1.

There -

YOUNG WOMAN *(calling out)*.

Somebody! Somebod -

Her voice is cut off. The machine sound takes over as the Screams.

Curtain